

ConnectEd Circles

BEARS

in the Classroom

Guided Play with Teddy Bears to Invite Feelings, Stories, and Healing

[Cover image: an overhead of the classroom bear basket on the low shelf — bears loose, not perfectly arranged, with one bear missing (it is with a child). Warm morning light. Caption: "The basket on the morning of the first day."]

A Practical Guide for Teachers

with companion notes for facilitators, coaches, supervisors, and directors

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ConnectEd Circles LLC

*Grounded in the Emotionally Responsive Practice of Bank Street College of Education,
founded by Lesley Koplou.*

A Letter to the Teacher

[A vertical photo of a hand-written morning note taped to the inside of a classroom door — the handwriting, the tape, the slight curl of the paper. Caption: "A note to myself, taped to the inside of the door."]

If you're reading this, someone handed you a stack of teddy bears and a manuscript and asked you to add one more thing to your week. We know. We've been the teacher in that moment — laminating machine still warm, twenty-six children about to walk in, a binder someone promised would "change everything" sitting unopened on the counter.

So before anything else: this guide isn't one more thing. It's a way of doing what you're already doing — greeting, comforting, holding, watching, surviving — with one small object in the room that makes a child's hardest feelings easier to put down somewhere.

We wrote this in the storytelling tradition of Amy Laura Dombro and the clinical tradition of Emotionally Responsive Practice at Bank Street College, founded by Lesley Koplow. The research is here, and it's strong. Wherever we could, we've told it through stories. Children deserve stories. Teachers do too.

Read what helps. Skip what doesn't. The bears will be patient with you.

— Gabriel and Skylar

There's a structural map of this guide at the back, in Appendix A. We put it there on purpose. Your first contact with this guide should be a child, not a color key.

IF YOU ONLY HAVE TEN MINUTES

If you don't have time to read this guide before Monday, take this with you:

- Choose bears that are 8–12 inches tall, soft, neutral-faced, and as close to identical as possible. Put them on a low shelf children can reach. Let each child choose one and name it.
- Watch before you talk. When a child is doing something with their bear, sit nearby. Let them tell you — or don't ask.
- When you do speak, speak about the bear, not the child. "Your bear looks worried" is something a three-year-old can hear. "You look worried" sometimes isn't.
- Never take a bear away as punishment.
- When something hard happens in the room, your steadiness is the intervention. The bear helps. You're the engine.

Everything else in this guide is an elaboration of those five things. If you want the why, read on.

Welcome, Teacher

[A wide shot of morning drop-off — a child in the doorway holding a bear against their shoulder the way you hold an infant. The adult is one step behind. The teacher is mid-crouch. Rain on the window. Caption: "Drop-off, a Tuesday in early October."]

Inside, the classroom was quiet as morning drop-off merged with free play. Outside, a light rain fell. The teacher sang "Hello, Everybody" as children arrived — some running in, some hanging back, some watching from the doorway.

What stood out was what several children were doing with their bears. Mateo hugged his bear tightly, whispering in its ear.

"How is your bear today, Mateo?" the teacher asked.

"I'm keeping her safe," Mateo said.

Across the room, Aliyah was pulling small wooden blocks off the shelf, one by one, and stacking them slowly around her bear.

"Tell me about what you're making for your bear," the teacher said, sitting down beside her.

"It's a super-house," Aliyah said, without looking up. "Because he's scared of thunder."

Near the cubbies, Sienna sat on the floor with her bear face-down in her lap. She wasn't doing anything with it — wasn't dressing it, wasn't talking to it — but her hand stayed on its back the whole morning, the way you'd keep a hand on a sleeping baby. The teacher noticed and didn't interrupt.

Three months earlier, Hurricane Helene had unleashed flooding across our region that destroyed homes, businesses, and roads. Adults struggled to make sense of what had happened. Children struggled more quietly. In the months that followed, caregivers did their best to comfort them. Some talked about the flood. Some made simple books about the storm. And some — like the teacher in this classroom — turned to teddy bears.

This guide is for the teacher who saw those three moments and thought, "Something real is happening here." The teacher who greets children every morning and navigates twenty transitions and twenty small griefs and twenty tiny triumphs before lunch. The teacher who already knows, deep down, that play is how children do the hardest work of their lives.

Be honest with us about what this is and isn't. It isn't a curriculum. There are no lesson plans in the traditional sense. What it offers instead is a way of thinking about children, play, and bears — grounded in research, shaped by years of classroom experience.

Mateo whispering. Aliyah building. Sienna keeping a hand on her bear's back. These look ordinary, easy to overlook. But play in early childhood is never simple, and stillness isn't

absence. Play is the primary way children express, process, and make sense of their experience — and sometimes play looks like a steady hand on a small soft thing.

Healing happens in everyday moments — a child whispering to a bear, a teacher gently naming feelings, a family adding a lullaby to the classroom, a child who just holds her bear and is allowed to.

That's what this guide is about.

PART ONE

Why Bears

Guided Play, Healing, and Connection

[A full-page image: a child sitting cross-legged on the reading rug, whispering into a bear's ear. Eyes closed. The adult is out of frame. Light coming in from one side — golden, not harsh. Caption: "A whispered secret, told to someone who will keep it."]

Why Bears

Some questions deserve a real answer, not a list of techniques. So before we say a word about how to use bears in your classroom, here's why.

Because feelings arrive faster than language.

A three-year-old isn't a small adult. They're a developing nervous system in a small body, navigating a world larger and louder than any system that young is built to manage. They're in love with their families. They're terrified of losing them. They're delighted by ordinary things — a puddle, a favorite cup, a song — and flattened by ordinary things — a new shoe, a substitute teacher, the wind against a window. Their feelings arrive faster than their language. They don't yet have the words to say "I'm anxious" or "I'm grieving" or "I don't understand what happened and I need someone to help me understand."

What they have, instead, is their body and their play.

When a child doesn't have words for a feeling, the feeling doesn't disappear. It gets bigger. It shows up as sleep trouble, as tantrum, as clinging, as silence, as the inability to join the morning circle. It shows up in a child's stomach. It shows up in their hands. It shows up in the sound their breath makes when a door closes too loudly. The feelings are there. The language isn't. That gap is the problem early childhood has always had to solve, and play is how it solves it.

"In play, children bring the realities of their world into a fictional context where it is uniquely safe to confront them, experience them, and practice ways of dealing with them."

— Peter Gray

A bear isn't a feeling. But a bear is a place a feeling can go. When a child puts a feeling on a bear — this bear is scared, this bear is lonely, this bear is mad — something important happens inside their nervous system. The feeling stops being an invisible thing happening to them. It becomes a visible thing, outside of them, that they can do something about. They can hold it. They can cover it with a blanket. They can build it a house of blocks. They can yell at it, forgive it, put it to bed, look at it from across the room, and come back to it.

The feeling becomes workable. And workable is the first step to bearable.

Because the bear is the safe distance that makes the unsayable sayable.

[A childhood bear photographed on a kitchen table or a quilt. Worn fur, uneven stuffing, one eye that has been sewn back on. No child in frame, just the bear and the light. Caption: "My own bear, still here."]

The psychoanalyst D. W. Winnicott, writing more than half a century ago, noticed something about very young children that no one had quite named before. When a child is separated from the person they need most, they don't tolerate the separation with nothing. They tolerate it with an object. A worn blanket. A scrap of satin. A stuffed animal. The object isn't the parent and isn't the child. It lives in between. Winnicott called it the transitional object, and he said it was the child's first "not-me" possession — the first piece of the world that was both the child's own and separate from them.

"It is in playing and only in playing that the individual child or adult is able to be creative and to use the whole personality, and it is only in being creative that the individual discovers the self."

— D. W. Winnicott

Teddy bears are a particular kind of transitional object. They have faces. They can be held, dressed, named, and talked to. Children naturally treat them as alive — not because they don't know the difference, but because bears are exactly the right size to carry the parts of a child's inner world that are too big to carry alone. A child who can't say "I am scared" can say "My bear is scared." A child who can't tell you about a flood can build a super-house for a bear who's afraid of thunder.

Because play is the work.

Modern early childhood has inherited a suspicion of play. It's been called a reward for finishing the "real" learning. It's been budgeted out of the day in the name of rigor. It's been eyed by anxious adults who wanted to be sure children were getting enough of the hard stuff. But the developmental science is clear: play isn't a detour from learning. Play is where learning begins.

"Play is often talked about as if it were a relief from serious learning. But for children, play is serious learning. Play is really the work of childhood."

— Fred Rogers

Sandra Russ has spent her career documenting that pretend play is associated with positive mood and coping ability in childhood, and with creative and emotional skills years later in adolescence and adulthood. Kathy Hirsh-Pasek and Roberta Golinkoff, whose work defines the field of playful learning, have shown that children learn more vocabulary, more spatial reasoning, and more self-regulation in guided play than in either free play or direct instruction. Vivian Gussin Paley, the kindergarten teacher who changed how educators think about classroom narrative, put it simply: children's imaginations are how they become themselves.

When a child transforms a stick into a wand, a block into a superhero, or a bear into a scared little brother, they're practicing the highest forms of thought — symbolic reasoning, perspective-taking, story — in the one medium where practice is safe.

Because your nervous system is the room.

[Hands in a lap holding a mug. Nothing else in frame. Hands at rest between a hard moment and the next one. Caption: "Between one child's hard moment and the next."]

There's one more answer to the question "why bears," and it's about you. A bear only works because a regulated adult is nearby. The science isn't subtle. Young children can't calm their own nervous systems. They borrow yours. If your nervous system is steady, theirs begins to steady with it. If your nervous system is in fight or flight, theirs matches you instead.

"A regulated, calm adult can regulate a dysregulated, anxious child. A dysregulated adult can never regulate a dysregulated child."

— Dr. Bruce Perry

Stephen Porges, whose polyvagal theory reshaped how we understand human stress and connection, calls this neuroception — the unconscious process by which one nervous system reads another for cues of safety or danger. A child's neuroception is acute. They're reading your face, your tone, your shoulders, the speed of your breath, before they can read a single word on the wall. They calibrate themselves to you, either way.

The bears don't work because they're bears. They work because they're in the hands of an adult who's attending to them, and who's therefore also attending to the child. The whole practice rests on this. The bear is the object. You are the regulation. The child is the story.



That's our answer. Bears aren't an activity. They're a relationship made visible — a place for feelings that have nowhere else to go, held by a nervous system that can hold them, in the one medium a young child can actually use to do the work of becoming themselves.

Everything that follows — the guided-play posture, the daily rhythms, the monthly themes, the reflection groups, the director's chapter at the back — answers the question of how. The why is above. Carry it with you into the rest.

How It Works: Guided Play

The method that lets bears do what we just said they do has a name in the field: guided play.

Guided play lives between free play (children alone, no adult involvement) and directed play (adults in charge, children following instructions). It's what happens when the environment has

been prepared by a thoughtful adult, the child is free to follow their own curiosity, and the adult is nearby — noticing, joining, wondering — without taking over.

When Aliyah built a "super-house" around her bear because "he's scared of thunder," nobody told her to do that. No lesson plan called for it. But the blocks were there, the bear was there, and a caring teacher was nearby. That's guided play. You prepare the environment; the child does the meaning-making. If the teacher had never set the blocks within reach, or had interrupted to say "Aliyah, we're doing morning meeting now," the super-house would never have existed.

Play therapists have said the same thing for a century, from different angles. Engaging a child through a symbolic object — a doll, a puppet, a bear — lets the adult ask open-ended questions about the object rather than the child. That's therapeutic distance. We aren't therapists. But the distance still works. When you wonder aloud about the bear, the child can meet you there in a way they can't always meet you when you're asking about them.

Notice • Join • Make Meaning

If you take only three words from this book, take these. This is the posture of the practice. Everything else — the materials, the routines, the monthly themes, the tools at the back — is in service of these three words.

[A candid of an adult sitting on the floor beside a child at play — both looking at the same thing, neither looking at the camera. Body turned toward body. Not teaching, not interrupting. Caption: "Sitting beside, not in front of."]

Notice

What is the child showing through their play, their body, and their bear? Before you say anything, watch. Watch the child's hands. Their posture. Their face. Notice what they do with the bear before you interrupt to ask about it. Noticing is the first act of respect; it says, without words, "I see that something real is happening here."

Join

How can you come close without taking over? Sit nearby. Use gentle language. Follow the child's lead. If a child is building a house around their bear, don't ask what they're building. Watch. Let them tell you — or not. Your job is to be a witness the child trusts enough to keep playing in front of. That's harder than it sounds.

Make Meaning

What might this experience hold for the child? This is where wondering lives. Not explaining — wondering. "I notice your bear is hiding under the blanket. I wonder what it needs." You don't need to know the answer. The child doesn't either. Wondering, together, is the work.

We return to this posture in depth in Part Three. Carry the three words with you until then.

Mirror, Don't Fix

Emotionally Responsive Practice teaches us to be a good mirror for the children in our care. A good mirror acknowledges both positive and negative feelings, both positive and negative experiences, with acceptance. It doesn't rush to reassure. It doesn't soften what's hard. It reflects back what's true.

With bears, mirroring sounds like this:

- "Your bear looks worried today. I wonder what happened."
- "It sounds like your bear is really mad. That's a big feeling. What does your bear need right now?"
- "Your bear missed you over the weekend. Coming back after being away can stir up lots of feelings."

Notice what these statements have in common: they're about the bear, not the child. That's the safe distance. The child can hear "your bear is scared" in a way they can't yet hear "you are scared." From that safety, they can begin to speak.

Amy Laura Dombro calls this kind of language mirror talk — reflecting back what you see a child doing without evaluation or praise. "You are stacking the blocks one by one" is a mirror. "Good job!" isn't. With bears, the mirror gets a third point of reflection: you're reflecting the child back to themselves through the safe distance of the bear.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

Think about your own childhood. Was there an object — a stuffed animal, a blanket, a pillow, a particular book — that was especially important to you? What did it do for you that the adults in your life couldn't? Share the object with your group if you're comfortable. Listen for the feeling underneath the memory, not the object itself.

This question isn't a warm-up. It's the first time we're inviting you to meet your own Little Self — the child you used to be, who's in the room with you every morning whether you notice or not. We return to your Little Self in Part Four. For now, just notice that the question you sat with is one of the most important questions in this guide.

Getting Your Bears Ready

[The bears on the day they arrive: still in their packaging or freshly unboxed on a classroom table, a few already pulled out. Identical, clean, blank. Caption: "Twenty-six identical bears, a few hours before they become twenty-six different ones."]

Before bears can do their work, someone has to choose them and prepare the classroom. This matters more than you might think.

Choose bears that are 8 to 12 inches tall, made from soft plush, with neutral or sweet facial expressions. Not cartoon characters. Not branded toys. Not realistic wild animals. And — importantly — the bears should be identical, or as close to identical as possible, when they arrive.

Why identical? Because when every bear starts the same, the child becomes the one who makes it unique. The naming, the dressing, the personalizing — that's the identity work. That's the guided play. Your job is to choose the canvas. The child paints it.

Practical decisions to make before Day One

- Where will the bears live when children aren't holding them? (A low shelf, a basket, a "bear home" corner — not a cabinet.)
- How will you wash them, and how often? (Pillow case, cold water, air dry. Label a rotation.)
- What happens when a child wants to bring their bear from home instead? (Our recommendation: their home bear is always welcome to visit. The classroom bear stays at school. Many children will hold both.)
- How will bears be introduced to a child who joins mid-year? (Keep two or three unused bears in reserve. The arrival ceremony matters as much in February as in September.)
- What do you do when a bear is lost or damaged? (Plan a ritual. "Our bear is away for a visit." Have a backup ready.)
- Who on your team is the point person when a child's bear play surfaces something hard? (Decide before the first hard moment, not during it.)

Belonging Is Protection

[The classroom family wall or cubby area — children's family photos visible, a small shelf of books in multiple languages, a child's drawing of their own home. Bears not in this photo. The ground they stand on is. Caption: "The wall where every family has a place."]

A note before we go further. The children in your classroom aren't abstract. They're arriving from real families, into a real country, in a real moment. Some of them carry questions adults haven't asked them out loud: Am I safe here? Is my family safe here? Is the way I am, the language I speak, the body I have, welcome here?

Children don't wait for adults to speak these questions. They feel the answers in our bodies, our materials, our books, our music, our silences. The bear practice is one small way to answer them — yes, you're welcome; yes, your bear can have a family that looks like yours; yes, your bear can speak the language you speak at home; yes, you can be sad about what's happening in the world and we won't tell you to be quiet about it.

There's no emotionally responsive classroom that isn't also a place where every child is told, in a hundred small ways every day, that they're wanted here. The bears help us do that. They don't replace it.

What This Practice Cannot Do

Before we go any further, a short list of honest limits.

Bears can't replace mental health care. A child showing signs of clinical trauma — frozen affect, persistent regression, repetitive traumatic play that doesn't move — needs a clinician, not a bear. The bear is a complement, never a substitute.

Bears can't fix a classroom that isn't safe in other ways. If the room is chaotic, if discipline is punitive, if children's families aren't welcomed, if the curriculum is rigid and joyless, the bears won't save it. They require a classroom that's already trying.

Bears can't do the work of an absent adult. A child who's being neglected at home cannot be held by a stuffed animal. The bear can offer comfort. It cannot offer attachment. That's your work.

Bears can't make a teacher's burnout disappear. If you're exhausted, the bears won't refill you. Tend yourself first. Use your reflection group. Ask for help.

Naming what bears can't do is part of taking them seriously. They're a small, soft, powerful tool. The relationship is the work. The bear just makes it safe enough to begin.

PART TWO

Bringing Bears to Life

Guided Play in Your Classroom

[A photograph of the bears introduced to the class on Day One — lined up on the meeting rug, faces toward the empty circle where children will sit. Morning light. Caption: "The morning we introduced them."]

Bringing Bears to Life

You have your bears. You know where they'll live. Now: how do you make them real?

The answer is guided play. You prepare the environment with care, introduce bears with warmth, and then stay present while children lead. This isn't passive work. It's one of the most intentional things a teacher can do.

Things We Never Do With Bears

Before we talk about what to do with bears, a short list of what we never do. Keep these in front of you in the first weeks. They're the floor of the practice.

- We never take a bear away as punishment or consequence.
- We never use the cozy corner as a timeout.
- We never insist a child engage with their bear, and we never remove a bear from a child who doesn't want to let go.
- We never rush big play to a tidy ending.
- We never interpret a child's bear story out loud as if it were a diagnosis. We wonder, we stay close, and — when needed — we bring what we saw to a supervisor.
- We never use a bear to shame, compare, or sort children ("Your bear is being a good listener — why aren't you?").
- We never pretend a bear can do what a person has to do — hold a child who is grieving, call a family back, repair a ruptured relationship.

These aren't style preferences. They're the conditions under which the practice works. Break one of them and the bear becomes a tool of control instead of a companion for feeling. Hold the line.

Prepare • Introduce • Stay With

Prepare

Before children arrive, think about the environment. Are bears visible and reachable? Are materials available for the kind of play you're inviting — fabric for dressing, shoeboxes for homes, small blankets for wrapping, a few accessories (a doctor kit, a phone, a toy suitcase)? Is

there a cozy corner where a child can go with their bear when feelings get big? Preparation isn't decoration. It's the invitation.

Introduce

Bring children into the experience with a gentle invitation, not a directive. "The bears are wondering what it's like in our classroom today" is different from "Everyone take your bear and sit in the circle." The first invites curiosity. The second invites compliance. In the first week, let the bears be new. Let children circle them, watch them, touch them carefully. Resist the urge to move quickly into routine.

Stay With

Once play begins, your job is to follow. Watch. Sit nearby. Use wondering language: "I notice your bear is building a very tall tower." Resist the urge to direct, to ask leading questions, to hurry the play toward a tidy ending. Children need time with their feelings. Bears help them take that time. Your stillness — your willingness to simply be there without making anything happen — is often the most active thing in the room.

Bears in Your Daily Rhythms

Bears work best when they're woven into the fabric of your day — not as a separate "bear time" but as companions present when children need them. Below are the everyday moments where guided play with bears does its quietest, most powerful work. For each rhythm, we offer one short teacher script. Use the words, or don't. They're less important than the steadiness behind them.

A note on why rhythms matter at all: a child's nervous system is perpetually asking, "Is this place safe?" Predictable rituals are how we answer yes. When the same song plays at circle, the same hook holds their jacket, the same bear waits on the same shelf every morning, the child's body learns to drop out of high alert and into learning. You aren't decorating the day with rituals. You're setting the thermostat of the room.

[The daily visual schedule on the wall, with a small bear propped next to one of the icons. Caption: "The bear who knows what happens next."]

Arrival

After Hurricane Helene, many children struggled with separation at drop-off. Bears became steady companions during arrivals — holding a bear made goodbyes easier and offered continuity from home to classroom. A bear can stand in for the parent who isn't yet back, and the teacher who isn't yet available. It holds the middle.

"Your bear has been waiting for you. Would you like to hold her while we say goodbye to Mom?" If a child can't release the parent, let them hold both. Let the bear join the goodbye. A long drop-off isn't a failure; it's the work.

Morning Meeting

Check in with bears: "How is your bear feeling today?" Use a feelings chart so children can show rather than just tell. Add a bear song to your gathering routine. Over time, this becomes ritual.

"Our bears have all had different mornings. Let's go around the circle. Your bear can tell us one thing — just one thing — about how this morning has been." Some children will speak. Some will whisper. Some will pass. All three are participation.

Transitions

Predictable bear routines make transitions smoother because children know the bear is secure. The bear stays, the child moves, and they're reunited.

"Bears rest here while we wash hands. When you come back, your bear will still be here, and we'll go outside together." Narrate the journey so the child can hold it in their head.

After Hard Moments

Fire drills, conflicts, unexpected changes, community crises. These are the moments when children need their bears most. Make bears available, not required. "Would you like to hold your bear for a minute?" is a choice that feels like care.

"That was a lot. Your body is still a little buzzy. Would you like to hold your bear while we sit? We don't have to do anything yet. We can just be here with our bears." Give the body five minutes before the words.

Rest Time

Many children who resist resting will settle with their bear against their chest. The bear provides sensory comfort and relational safety that make rest possible.

"Where does your bear want to sleep today? On your chest? Next to your ear? Under your arm?" Choice inside a routine is how children practice agency without losing the safety of predictability.

Story Time

Read books that connect to what children are experiencing. Let children hold their bears while they listen. The bear becomes a co-listener, making the story feel safer.

"This book is about a family that had to move. Your bear might have some feelings about it. If your bear gets sad or scared or happy, that's okay — give your bear a little squeeze."

Daniel Siegel and Tina Payne Bryson remind us that storytelling is how children integrate experience — how they take the raw material of a scary or confusing event and turn it into a

narrative they can carry. The bear makes that narrative safer to tell, because the story is about the bear, not about the child.

The Cozy Corner

[The cozy corner. A rug, a floor pillow, a small basket of books, a few bears. Soft light, maybe from a small lamp or a window. Empty of children. Caption: "The cozy corner, empty and waiting."]

Every classroom with bears needs a cozy corner — a physical and emotional safe haven where children can go to regulate, rest, or just be quiet with their bear. This isn't a timeout corner. It isn't a punishment. It's a place where a child can say, with their body, "I need something small and soft right now."

"A trauma-informed classroom should feel like a warm hug, where every corner whispers, 'You belong here.'"

— Dr. Caelan Soma

Make it cozy: a rug, a beanbag or low cushion, a blanket, a basket of familiar books. Keep a few bears nearby. Place it slightly out of the main flow but still visible to you. A child in the cozy corner should never feel hidden or alone — just held by the room.

Introduce it as a gift: "This is our cozy corner. It's for when your bear needs a rest, or you do." Model using it yourself. Over time, children learn what many adults never do: that noticing you need rest is strength, not weakness.

There's a neurological reason the distinction between cozy corner and timeout matters. A dysregulated child isn't processing language in the higher regions of the brain — they're scanning their environment for threat. A safe haven, chosen voluntarily, tells the nervous system that it's safe to come back from that scan. A timeout, imposed by an adult, confirms the opposite: something is wrong, and I'm being sent away from the people I need. The physical space can look identical. The meaning is the difference between regulation and shame.

A note about a child who goes to the cozy corner and stays. The cozy corner is a safe haven, but it isn't a replacement for an adult. A child who has been there for ten or fifteen minutes alone is no longer regulating — they're withdrawing, and they need you. Sit nearby. Don't ask them to come out. Bring your own bear, or a book, or a quiet hand on the rug between you. The cozy corner does its work in relationship, not in isolation. If a child consistently retreats there for long stretches, that's information — bring it to your weekly group or your supervisor.

FROM A CLASSROOM · BUNCOMBE COUNTY, DECEMBER

Jayden had been at the window every morning since the flood. He didn't cry. He didn't ask questions. He just stood there, watching the parking lot where, three months ago, water had come up to the lower branches of the oak tree. On the third week of bears, his teacher

brought her own bear over and sat beside him. She didn't ask him to turn around. She didn't ask him what he was looking at. She just sat down and let him keep watching. After a long time, Jayden turned to her and said, "Look. The water's gone now." He said it to the bear.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

Share a daily rhythm in your classroom that has become a kind of quiet ritual, with or without bears. What does that moment do for the children? What does it do for you? Is there a rhythm in your day where bears aren't yet showing up, but could? What would change if they did?

PART THREE

Noticing What Bears Show Us

Reading Play as the Language of Children

[A close-up of a child's hands wrapping a bear in a small blanket. Hands in focus; the child's face softly out of focus in the background. Afternoon light. Quiet, deliberate. Caption: "Tucking the bear in."]

Noticing What Bears Show Us

In Part One, we introduced the Notice · Join · Make Meaning posture. Now we go deeper. This part is about what happens when you actually watch a child with a bear — what you might notice, what it might mean, and what you do with it.

Jack Shonkoff, one of the most important voices in early childhood science, puts it this way:

"Children learn most from the relationships that are most predictable, warm, and attuned. Everything else — curriculum, environment, materials — is in service of those relationships."

— Jack Shonkoff

With bears, you get to do exactly that. The bear is the third thing in the conversation. It gives you a new language for knowing the child.

Inviting and Containing

There's a fundamental tension in this work. You want to welcome children's big feelings. You want them to know that anger, fear, sadness, rage, and grief aren't forbidden. At the same time, you want the classroom to feel safe. Boundaried. Not chaotic.

Lesley Koplow, who shaped this entire practice, named the tension with elegant simplicity:

"We invite the feeling. We contain the behavior."

— Lesley Koplow

Inviting sounds like: "Your bear seems really angry. That's a big feeling. Tell me more."

Containing sounds like: "I won't let your bear hurt the other bears. We can put pillows between them, and your bear can still be angry over here." Both can happen in the same breath. Both have to. A classroom that only invites becomes chaotic. A classroom that only contains goes silent on the inside.

This is the central skill of this work — learning where that line is. Learning to welcome feelings while maintaining structure. Learning to let a child express rage at their bear without letting that rage wash over everyone in the room.

The Hot Lava Problem

[A dramatic-play shot: two children on the rug, one with a bear mid-air, the other's bear sprawled. Motion, intensity, but also contained — the teacher's knee visible in the edge of the frame, present and steady. Caption: "Anger with a place to go."]

When adults shut down dark, scary, or aggressive themes in pretend play — the bear getting hurt, the bear being mean, the bear destroying the house — those feelings don't disappear. They go underground. We sometimes call this the hot lava problem: the unexpressed rage and grief and fear bubble beneath the surface until they erupt as real behavior, against real children, often without warning.

Symbolic play is the pressure valve. The bear absorbing the anger is what prevents another child from absorbing it instead. When you say yes to the bear, you say yes to pressure release. The child beats the bear with purpose, not to hurt anyone. The child hides the bear under a blanket, not to disappear from class. The child says, "My bear wants to leave and never come back," and instead of collapsing into that feeling, they can move through it. The feeling got a voice. The body can relax.

This isn't permission for chaos. It's permission for honesty. And honesty, expressed safely, is what frees a child to be present for learning and connection.

When Bear Play Gets Big

You'll see bear play escalate. Children will get loud. They'll make their bears fight. They'll create apocalypse scenarios. They'll want their bears to die, to hurt, to be abandoned. The first time it happens, you might feel alarmed.

Don't be. This is the practice working.

What matters is the difference between traumatic play and dramatic play. A child building elaborate stories about their bear's terrible day, expressing rage and fear and sorrow, and then moving on to snack — that's dramatic play. The work is happening. A child who returns to the same traumatic narrative compulsively, who seems stuck, who can't access relief — that's different. That's a signal. That's when you call in a mental health consultant.

"Post-traumatic play is obsessively repeated, and so literal in its execution that an observer can often guess the exact nature of the trauma with very few other clues."

— Lenore Terr

Both kinds of play are meaningful. The difference isn't the theme — it's whether the story moves, whether the child's affect has range, and whether anything gets released in the telling. Eliana Gil describes ordinary dramatic play as having "a natural cure": the child faces a threat, turns the tables, discovers mastery, and walks away a little lighter. Traumatic play lacks that cure. It wears grooves instead of clearing them.

	Dramatic Play	Traumatic Play
Theme	Dark, big, wild, scary — can include violence, loss, abandonment.	Often the same dark theme. Theme alone doesn't distinguish.
Movement	Moves. Changes. Resolves, even if only for a moment.	Stuck. Repeats in near-identical form. No resolution.
Affect	Child shows a range — fear, excitement, laughter, concentration.	Affect is flat, frozen, or disconnected. Or: unmodulated terror.
After the play	Child returns to the group. Eats. Plays something else. Sleeps.	Child can't leave it. Behavior outside the play doesn't recover.
What you do	Stay close. Wonder. Contain behavior, invite feeling. Trust the process.	Still stay close, but also document, tell a supervisor, bring in consultation.

While You Wait

[A small notebook open on a clipboard, a teacher's handwritten observation visible but not readable. A pen resting beside it. No child; just the evidence that someone was paying attention. Caption: "The notebook that holds what the day holds."]

You may not have a mental health consultant on speed dial, and the supervision conversation may be days away. While you wait, here's what you can do in the moment without overstepping your role:

- Stay close, stay quiet. Sit at the child's level. Don't narrate. Don't redirect. Your steady presence is the intervention. The child's body can begin to regulate simply because a trusted adult is near.
- Widen the play, gently, only if the child invites it. "Your bear has been having a really hard day. I wonder if there's anything that helps your bear feel a little safer." Then wait. If the child doesn't take the offer, drop it. You aren't fixing the problem. You're suggesting that safety is possible.
- Document what you saw. As soon as you can, write down — in plain words, without interpretation — what the child did and said. Include time of day, who else was nearby, and your own felt response. This document is what makes the supervision conversation useful when it happens.

Staying close isn't the same as doing nothing. It's the most skilled thing you can do. Children in hard play need a witness, not a rescuer.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

Bring a child's bear play to supervision when:

- The same traumatic scene repeats for more than two weeks without any change.
- The child's affect during bear play is consistently flat, numb, or disconnected.
- A child suddenly stops engaging with their bear after a period of strong connection.
- You find yourself unable to watch the play without distress.

These aren't moments where something is wrong with the child. They're moments where a child needs more than the theme or the classroom can hold on its own.

PART FOUR

Tending Your Own Practice

Because how you are is how they will be

[A childhood bear on a grown-up desk or nightstand — bear in focus, a to-do list or a mug slightly out of focus behind it. Caption: "My Little Self, still showing up to work."]

Tending Your Own Practice

This work asks a great deal of the adults who do it. Children bring the whole inside of themselves into your room every morning, and they look to you to help them carry it. You can't carry it steadily if you aren't tending to your own inside too.

This part is about that. Your Little Self. Your Me Check. Your weekly practice. Your reflection group. Your steadiness isn't optional; it's the ground the bear practice stands on.

A NOTE BEFORE YOU READ THIS PART

What follows asks you to think about your own childhood. We use the phrase Little Self to name the part of you that remembers what it felt like to be small. For most readers, this material will organize something that's been around for a while, and it'll feel useful to have words for it.

For some readers, it may surface more than the page can hold. If the work of noticing your own Little Self brings up grief or distress that doesn't settle, that's information, and it deserves real support — not a paperback alone at midnight. Bring it to your own therapist, your supervisor, or a trusted reflection partner before you bring it into the classroom.

This work is real. It belongs in a held space. We're naming it here because we trust that you'll know the difference between thinking and reaching for help, and we want you to have the warning before the welcome.

Your Little Self in the Classroom

All of us were once children in somebody's classroom.

That's the simplest and hardest thing about this work. The teacher you are now grew out of the child you were then, and that child is in the room with you every day, whether you know it or not. We sometimes call this your Little Self. She's the part of you that remembers what it felt like to be small, to be misread, to be held, to be lonely, to be loved.

Most days, your Little Self stays quiet. The professional adult who plans the day and greets the families and prepares the snack is in charge. But some days — the day a child screams at

drop-off, the day a parent says something sharp, the day everything in the world feels heavier than it should — your Little Self wakes up. She climbs into your lap. And the child in front of you is suddenly being met not by your professional adult self, but by the seven-year-old who didn't have what she needed.

This isn't a failure. It's a feature of the work. Teachers feel things adults in other professions don't have to feel, because we're constantly being invited — by the smells, the music, the smallness of the chairs, the children themselves — back into the place we came from.

What we can do is notice when our Little Self has woken up, and not let her run the room. The Me Check below is one tool for this. The weekly reflection group is another. A trusted colleague who can say, kindly, "I think your Little Self is in the room right now," is the most important tool of all.

Some prompts for your own quiet time, perhaps in your journal or in the first minutes of a reflection group:

- What was it like to be little?
- Where were the physical places that kept you safe — a grandmother's kitchen, a tree in the backyard, a closet, a porch?
- Who were the adults who saw you? Who didn't?
- What worries did you carry that adults around you didn't know about?
- Is there a child in your classroom right now who reminds you of your Little Self? What does she need from you that you didn't get?

The point isn't to reopen old wounds. The point is to build enough familiarity with your own Little Self that, when she shows up at school, you recognize her. Once you can recognize her, you can love her — and that's what frees you to be the steady adult the children in your room need you to be.

Stephen Porges writes that "only when we are in a calm physiological state can we convey cues of safety to another." If your social-engagement system is online — soft eyes, open face, warm voice — the child's system comes online too. If yours is locked in defense, theirs matches you. The teacher's steadiness isn't a bonus. It's the mechanism.

"I cannot make them calm by telling them to be calm. I can only make them calm by being calm. On the days I am not, I tell them so. That is the work."

— a teacher in our network

The Me Check

[A wallet-sized Me Check card, photographed on a desk next to a coffee cup and a set of keys. Handwritten, a little worn.]
Caption: "The card in my wallet."

Once a day, take ten seconds. That's all. Before you begin your morning, or between activities, or as you look at the sign-in sheet.

Ask yourself two questions:

- How am I right now, in my body? (Tight jaw, shallow breath, quick pulse, heavy shoulders? Or settled, warm, open?)
- Can I be present for a child who needs me right now?

If the answer to the second question is yes — good. Go. If the answer is no, you aren't failing. You're in possession of information. Take three slow breaths. Ask your co-teacher to cover you for a minute. Or name it out loud: "I'm having a hard morning. Thank you for being patient with me." Children who hear that sentence are learning something they'll need for the rest of their lives.

This isn't a meditation. It isn't a fix. It's a boundary between your inner life and the child's inner life. It's how you keep your stuff from landing on them. It's how you practice, a thousand times a year, the discipline of showing up for them and not for yourself.

Top-Down and Bottom-Up: What Behavior Is Telling You

One reframe will save you more exhausted evenings than almost any other. The psychologist Mona Delahooke distinguishes between two very different kinds of behavior: top-down behaviors come from the thinking brain and respond to logic, instruction, and negotiation; bottom-up behaviors come from the brainstem and limbic system and are pure autonomic stress response — fight, flight, freeze. Top-down behavior is a child choosing. Bottom-up behavior is a child surviving.

*"When we punish a bottom-up behavior, we can easily make matters worse.
Bottom-up behaviors do not respond to rewards, consequences, or punishments.
They respond to co-regulation and safety."*

— Dr. Mona Delahooke

The implication for your day is enormous. The child melting down at transitions isn't defying you. The child lashing out at a bear after a fire drill isn't being rude. Their nervous system has gone below the cortex, and the only intervention that works is to bring it back up — with a quiet voice, a lowered body, a soft thing to hold. That's why the bear belongs in those moments. And why the calm adult nearby is the whole intervention.

Once the child is back online, then — later, not in the middle — you can have the top-down conversation. Naming what happened. Wondering what helped. Practicing what might help next time. Never in the middle of a bottom-up storm.

How You Are Is How They Will Be

The Circle of Security is a model born from decades of research on attachment. It names the core things every child needs to feel safe enough to grow — a secure base to venture from, and a safe haven to return to. We'll teach the circle to you in the table below. But here's the secret: children don't learn attachment because you teach it. They learn it because you are it.

How you are is how they will be. If you're reactive, they become reactive. If you're open to their hardness, they become open to their own. If you apologize and repair when you make a mistake, they learn that mistakes are survivable. If you're listening, they feel heard. If you're present, they know what it feels like to belong to someone.

This is why the Me Check matters. This is why we ask you to know your Little Self. This is why your own practice — your therapy, your supervision, your reflection group — isn't optional. It's the foundation of the work.

The Circle of Security in Plain Language

The Circle of Security maps two halves of the attachment need — what children need when they venture out, and what they need when they come back. Here's how it shows up in a classroom of bears:

Child's need	What it looks like	What the bear helps with
Watch over me.	The child glances at the teacher from across the room. Not asking for anything; checking that you're there.	A bear held, propped on the teacher's lap, or placed where the child can see it is a second watcher. The child can hold the bear's gaze when the teacher is busy.
Delight in me.	The child brings you something — a drawing, a rock, a story — and looks up to see your face.	A bear can delight in the child when the teacher isn't free in that moment. "Tell your bear. Your bear is going to love this."
Help me.	The child comes to you overwhelmed, stuck, hurt.	The bear is the child's first help — a soft thing to hold while the child gathers themselves to ask you for what they need.
Enjoy with me.	The child wants you to see what they see, laugh at what they laugh at.	A teacher sitting on the floor with a bear is instantly at the child's level. The bear is an excuse to slow down and be pleased with something small.
Protect me.	The child needs you to be in charge of what is too big for them — a fire drill, a fight, a scary story.	A bear in the child's arms during a hard moment isn't protection. But it's a tangible reminder that the child is being held by something.

Child's need	What it looks like	What the bear helps with
Organize my feelings.	The child is overwhelmed and doesn't yet have the words.	The bear holds the feeling the child can't yet name. "Your bear is really angry." "Your bear is scared." The child can agree with the bear.

Families Are Part of the Healing

[A family conference moment — a parent, a teacher, and a bear journal open on the table between them. The parent's hand on a page. No faces needed. Caption: "The conference where the bear journal did the talking."]

The bear does its best work when the family is part of the story.

Send the Dear Families letter (Appendix B) at the start of the year, in every language your families read. Invite a brief meeting or phone call to answer questions. Some families will love it immediately. Some will ask good, skeptical questions. ("Is this a toy? Is this babyish? Is this hygienic? Is this religious? Is this political?") Most of these questions are kind, and all of them are welcome.

Invite families into the practice without requiring anything. If a family wants to send a photo to live in the bear's home, welcome. If a family wants to share a lullaby in their home language that the class can sing to the bears, welcome. If a family wants nothing to do with it and simply wants their child to have a quiet companion in class, welcome. The bear practice is an invitation, not a curriculum the family has to buy into.

Stay alert to families who have reason to be wary. A family that's been surveilled, reported, or suspected — by schools, social services, immigration, or a child's other parent — may hear a question about the bear as a question about their parenting. Be transparent. Explain what you're doing and why. Don't require engagement. Offer, always.

If a family asks to take the bear home, decide in advance whether that's okay in your program. Either answer is defensible, as long as it's consistent. "Our bears stay here because that's how we keep them steady for every child" is a real answer. So is, "Our bears go home with children who need them, and we have a sign-out sheet." Pick one. Stick to it.

When you hold a conference, bring the child's bear journal. Read the child's words with the family. You'll be surprised how often a parent's face changes when they hear their child described in this way — as a thinker, a feeler, a person with a story. The bear is a kind of interpreter. It lets the family see their child the way you do.

Your Weekly Practice

Here's what we ask of you, every week:

- One bear moment a day. At the end of each day, write one sentence about something you noticed. Sticky note, phone, back of a receipt — the medium doesn't matter. Over a school year, this becomes around 180 sentences. That collection is the most honest data anyone will ever generate about your teaching. At the end of the year, read them in order. You'll be surprised by what you find.
- One Me Check, every morning, before the children arrive. Ten seconds. Two questions. (See the wallet-card version in Part Six.)
- One reflection group, every week (or every other week, minimum). Thirty to forty-five minutes. Bring one bear moment and one question. Listen to two other teachers' moments before you say anything about your own. (See the agenda in Part Six.)
- One conversation with a family about bears every two weeks. A line in the newsletter. A sentence at pickup. A quick note home. Families stay partners when they're included, not just informed.
- One moment of repair, whenever you need it. If you snapped, lost your patience, missed a child's signal — go back. Say, "I wasn't my best self with you this morning. I'm sorry." Then let them answer, or not. Repair is more important than never rupturing. Children learn from repair what they can't learn from perfection.

PART FIVE

Bears Across the Year

Ten themes that follow the emotional arc of a school year, plus four anytime themes for when life asks for them

[A full-width landscape of the classroom bear shelf across the seasons: a September row of pristine bears, the same shelf in December dressed in holiday scarves, the same shelf in May with well-loved bears and faded ribbons. Caption: "One shelf, three seasons."]

How to Use This Part

The themes in this section follow the emotional arc of a school year. They begin with safety and belonging, move into feelings and identity, navigate the hard middle — loss, separation, fear — and close with integration, celebration, and goodbye.

This isn't a pacing guide. If your classroom is still working on safety in November, stay there. If a family crisis makes Lost & Found urgent in October, move it forward. Follow what the children need, not the calendar.

Bears aren't a unit. They're a year-long companion. The themes are invitations, not assignments.

Each monthly theme contains four elements: a short essay about the heart of the theme; a teal box of concrete things to try this week; a cream story from a classroom; and a purple prompt for your reflection group. Where it's helpful, we add a peach box naming what to watch for in a child who might need more support.

September: A Safe Place for Bears

Everything begins here. Before children can express feelings, explore identity, or process loss, they need to know: this bear is safe, and so am I. Your entire first month is about safety. Not in the lecture sense — in the body sense. Children need to feel in their shoulders that this room is predictable, that their teacher is steady, that the bear will still be here tomorrow.

You're building the container. The themes that come later — loss, identity, goodbye — can only be held by a container that's strong. Spend September over-investing in rhythm, greeting, naming, and gentle introduction. Resist the urge to move fast.

[A first-day name tag on a bear — a child's handwriting, a piece of masking tape, tied with a ribbon. Caption: "Day one, ribbon and masking tape."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Welcome each bear by name on the first day.

- Use the same simple greeting song each morning for the whole month.
- Let children choose their bears from a basket. Don't assign. Choice is the first act of ownership.
- Give bears a home in the classroom that's visible from the door. Children should see the bears the moment they walk in.
- Take a photo of each child with their bear. Post them at child-height. Every child belongs here because the picture says so.
- Invite families to send one thing from home the bear can keep nearby — a photo, a small piece of fabric, a note in the family's language.

FROM A CLASSROOM

On the fourth day of school, Ms. Rosa noticed that Kai hadn't named his bear yet. Other children had already introduced theirs. Kai just held his at morning meeting, unnamed, in his lap. Ms. Rosa didn't push. On day eight, Kai came in with a folded piece of paper. "His name is Paciencia," he said quietly. "My abuela helped me pick it." "Paciencia," Ms. Rosa said. "That's a beautiful name." Kai sat down and held his bear close. He didn't say anything else that morning. He didn't need to.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

Think back to the first week of school this year. Which child took the longest to settle? What did that child teach you about safety?

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

Most children form a simple, consistent bond with their bear in the first three weeks. If a child by mid-October is still unable to tolerate the bear at all — actively rejecting it, refusing to be near it, destroying it repeatedly — that's information. It doesn't mean something is wrong. It means something is asking to be understood. Bring it to your reflection group.



October: Same & Different

Now that children and bears feel safe, they're ready for the question at the heart of identity: What makes me — and my bear — unique? This theme invites children to explore culture,

family, language, and body through their bears, with the same tenderness they've been holding them with.

Children are constantly learning that sameness is safe and difference is a little scary. The bear practice gives you a way to turn that on its head. Every bear looks the same when it arrives. Every bear becomes different because a child loved it into a specific life. Identity isn't a deficit. Identity is a story.

[Bears dressed by the children — fabric scraps, a tied-on scarf, mismatched buttons, a bit of sari silk, a yarn braid. Faces of the bears visible, faces of the children not. Caption: "Twenty-six bears, no two the same."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- "What color is your bear? Does your bear speak the same language you speak at home?" Listen to the answers.
- Dress the bears. Bring in fabric scraps from families, sari remnants, ribbon, yarn, a small box of buttons. Let children customize, redress, and re-customize.
- Make a class book: "Our Bears Are the Same and Different." Each page: "[Child's name]'s bear is — and —." Read it at morning meeting.
- Invite a family to come share a song or story from home that they would sing to a bear.
- Mirror play: hold your bear next to another child's bear. "These bears are alike. These bears are different. Both bears belong here."

FROM A CLASSROOM

Lina's family had arrived from Ukraine in August. In early October, when the class was dressing their bears, Lina tied her grandmother's scarf around her bear's head. Her teacher, Ms. Devon, sat down beside her. "Tell me about your bear," she said. Lina spoke in Ukrainian for a minute, then stopped. She looked up. "She knows two languages," she said. "Like you," Ms. Devon said. "Like me."

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

Whose identity is most visible in your room right now? Whose is least visible? Where in the bear practice could that shift?



November: Together & Apart

Separation is one of the earliest and deepest human experiences. Every drop-off, every break, every goodbye activates a child's attachment system. Bears are the transitional object Winnicott wrote about — the steady companion that holds connection across distance.

November is when the holidays begin to shift the rhythm of the year. Extended families arrive. Children travel. Children don't travel. Some children go to a parent they haven't seen. Some children have lost someone who used to be at the Thanksgiving table. All of this lives inside the theme of together and apart.

[A bear sitting alone on a cubby shelf with a small paper heart taped to its paw — the kiss-heart from The Kissing Hand, waiting for the child to come back after the Thanksgiving break. Caption: "The heart that waited."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- "Where is your bear's family? Who does your bear miss?" Make a simple "bear families" wall with drawings.
- Read *The Kissing Hand*. Give each bear a small heart on its paw. "This is for when we're apart."
- Practice short separations: bear goes to the shelf, child plays nearby, bear comes back. Narrate the cycle.
- Before the Thanksgiving break, do a small bear goodbye: "Your bear will wait right here for you." After the break, a small welcome-back.
- For children traveling to a parent or relative they don't see often, let them take a photo of their bear "telling them they'll be back."

FROM A CLASSROOM

Aisha had been quiet all week. Her father was in the hospital. On Wednesday, she brought her bear to the window during choice time and stood there for a long time, not saying anything. Ms. Priya sat on the floor nearby with her own bear. After a few minutes, Aisha said, without turning around, "My bear's dad is in the hospital too." "Oh," Ms. Priya said. "That's a lot for your bear." "It is," Aisha said. Ms. Priya didn't ask whether Aisha's father was coming home. She just sat there with her bear, and after a while Aisha came over and leaned against her arm.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

What is your own relationship with separation? What happens in your body when a child cannot let go of a parent at drop-off? What do you need in that moment that you may not be getting?



December: The Many Feelings of Bears

By December, children have a relationship with their bears. Now that relationship can hold something harder: feelings. All of them. Not just happy.

The holidays surface every feeling a family has. Excitement and grief. Abundance and scarcity. Reunion and loss. Children will bring all of it to school, and most of them won't have words for it. The bear does.

[A bear propped against a simple child-made feelings chart — crayon faces for sad, mad, scared, happy — with a child's finger pointing to one of them. Caption: "My bear feels like this today."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Introduce a feelings chart at the bears' level. Children can point to the feeling for their bear, even if they can't claim it for themselves. "Your bear has been pretty quiet today. I wonder if your bear is feeling something big."
- Make a class book of feelings: "My bear feels — when —." Dictate the children's words.
- For children who have lost someone this year, leave space for their bear to miss someone. "Your bear can miss people too. That's okay."
- Sing "Bear's Heart Beats Slow, Bear's Heart Beats Fast" at morning meeting. Hand on your own heart. Hand on the bear's.

FROM A CLASSROOM

DeShawn's bear had been angry all week. He banged it on the floor during free play. He buried it under the pillows at rest time. At morning meeting he told the class, "My bear is mad." "What is your bear mad about?" Ms. Latrelle asked. "Everything," DeShawn said. Ms. Latrelle nodded. "Sometimes bears are mad at everything. That's a real feeling." She didn't try to talk him out of it. She just sat beside him through the week. By Friday, DeShawn was holding the bear in his lap again, rocking it, singing to it quietly.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

Which feelings are easiest for you to welcome in your classroom? Which ones make you want to redirect? What does that pattern tell you about your own history?



January: Lost & Found

Loss is one of the most universal human experiences and one of the least talked about with young children. A pet that died. A grandparent who moved away. A friend who left the school. A home that's no longer the home. Bears make it safe to speak of these things without having to call them by name.

January in our region, after Hurricane Helene, was a month of quiet loss. The flood had been in September, but the losses unfolded slowly — the uncle who moved, the friend who changed schools, the house that was still not rebuilt. Children have a way of returning to loss in winter. Be ready.

[A bear held on a lap during a read-aloud of a book about loss — the corner of the book, a small hand on the bear's belly, the teacher's knee beside. No faces. Caption: "Held while the story was hard."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Read *Ida Always* or *The Memory Box*. Let children hold their bears while you read. Don't ask them to share after.
- "Has your bear ever lost something? I wonder what your bear would want to find."
- Create a "Lost and Found" basket where children can place small paper drawings of things their bear is missing.
- Make space for goodbye rituals: for pets, for friends who have moved, for a home that's no longer there.
- Keep the door open for grief. Sometimes a child will tell you about a loss for the first time in January because the bear has made it possible.

FROM A CLASSROOM

On a Tuesday in January, Maya told her teacher, Ms. Beth, that her bear's grandmother had died. Maya's own grandmother had died in October. Maya hadn't talked about it at school. "I'm so sorry," Ms. Beth said. "That is a hard thing for your bear." "Yes," Maya said. "She was her favorite." "Do you want to tell me about her?" Maya did. For ten full minutes. Her

bear's grandmother baked bread and sang songs and had soft hands. At the end, Maya looked up. Ms. Beth took the bear's small paw in her hand. "It's okay to miss her," she said. Maya nodded. She held her bear and didn't say anything for a long time.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

What losses are your children carrying that you know about? What losses might they be carrying that you don't? How does loss show up in your own body when a child brings it into the room?



February: Scared & Safe

Children at this age oscillate between feeling powerful and feeling very small. They dream about superheroes and have nightmares about monsters. Bears can hold both sides at once — the big feelings of fear and the small experience of being comforted.

February is dark and cold and often long. Behavior gets bigger. Sleep gets weirder. Bodies are tired. This is the month to let bears do some of the biggest work of the year: holding fear, and letting it be okay to be scared.

[A bear tucked into a small nest of blanket in the "brave corner" — flashlight, a drawing of a monster taped to the wall, the bear's paw holding a crayon-drawn shield. Caption: "The brave corner, February."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Make a monsters-and-bears book. "My bear is scared of ——. My bear feels better when ——" Dictate.
- Practice superhero play with bears. "What could your bear do if it felt scared? What powers does your bear have?"
- Read *Go Away Big Green Monster* and then read it with the bears.
- Set up a "brave corner" in the cozy corner — a place where bears go when they're working on being brave.
- When a child reports a nightmare, let the bear receive it. "Could your bear carry that dream for you today?"

FROM A CLASSROOM

Elijah had told his teacher in January that he wasn't scared of anything. "I'm brave," he said. By mid-February, he was waking up with nightmares. At rest time on a Tuesday, he didn't close his eyes. His teacher, Mr. Dre, sat next to him. "How is your bear doing with sleep lately?" he asked. "Bad," Elijah said. "Yeah?" "She has bad dreams." "Brave bears can have bad dreams too," Mr. Dre said. Elijah nodded. He held the bear tighter. After a few minutes, he closed his eyes.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

What scares you in the classroom? The question isn't rhetorical. What do you need in order to stay with a child's fear instead of rushing to reassure it away?



March: Growing & Changing

Spring arrives and so does a shift. Children are noticeably different from September. Their voices are stronger. They play with more complexity. Their bear relationships have changed too. This theme invites children to notice their own growth — to look back at their own September selves with wonder.

Young children don't experience time linearly. March is when you can help them begin to. "I am different now than I was then" is one of the most important discoveries of childhood.

[Side-by-side photo wall: each child with their bear in September beside the same child with the same bear in March. Polaroid edges, crayon captions. Caption: "Then and now, same bear."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Pull out the photos you took in September of each child with their bear. Post them next to a new photo taken this week. "What is different? What is the same?"
- Read *Leo the Late Bloomer*. Ask: "What has your bear been learning?"
- Make growth books: "When I was little, my bear ——. Now my bear ——" Dictate.
- Plant something in the classroom with the bears as witnesses. Return to it every morning.
- Celebrate one small, specific thing each child has learned since September. Say it out loud to the bear.

FROM A CLASSROOM

On a rainy Thursday in March, Theo pulled his teacher, Ms. Nina, over to the photo wall. He pointed at his September picture. "I look different," he said. "You do," Ms. Nina said. They stood there for a minute. "My bear looks the same," Theo said. "Your bear is the same. You're the one who's been changing." Theo thought about that. Then he leaned against Ms. Nina's leg, holding the bear, and didn't say anything for a while.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

When you look at your own September self as a teacher and your March self, what has changed? What would be generous to yourself about that change?



April: Teddy Bear Town

This is where guided play reaches its fullest expression. Children build a world together — a town where their bears live, work, play, and belong. It draws on everything they've learned about identity, community, and cooperation.

Teddy Bear Town isn't a single activity. It's a weeks-long, child-driven project. You're the infrastructure. The children are the mayors, the architects, the doctors, the bakers, the neighbors. Your job is to say yes to their plans and provide just enough materials to keep the world growing.

[The block town in progress — a bear hospital sign in crayon, a bus made of a long block, a shelter made of two blocks and a scarf. Bears everywhere, one with a tiny drawn name tag. Caption: "Teddy Bear Town, the bus stop and the shelter."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Start with one block structure in the middle of the room. "This is the bears' town square. What does the town need?"
- Add roles: a bear hospital, a bear grocery, a bear library. Let children choose what the town needs.
- Make a town map together. Update it as the town grows.
- Invite a family member to visit Teddy Bear Town as a "special guest" who has a job in the real world that the town also needs.
- Photograph the town each day. Make a class book at the end of the month called "Our Town."

FROM A CLASSROOM

By the second week of Teddy Bear Town, the children had built a hospital, a grocery store, and a small library. On Wednesday, Priya said, "Our town needs a bus stop. My bear takes the bus." They built a bus stop. The next day, Marcus added a bus (a long block). Then Lena added a bus driver bear and a paper schedule. Then Sofia walked over with two more blocks and started building near the edge of the town. "What are you making?" Ms. Alex asked. Sofia kept building. "A house for the bears who don't have one," she said.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

What do your children's Teddy Bear Towns reveal about what they understand — and don't yet understand — about community? What is being worked out in the play?



May: Reunion & Discoveries

Before the goodbye, there is the looking back. This theme creates space for children to celebrate what they've learned about themselves, their bears, and each other. It isn't about assessment. It's about meaning-making.

May is the beginning of the end. Children can feel it in the air before adults tell them. Your job is to not rush past it. Let there be time for looking back before there's time for looking forward.

[An open bear journal on a rug — a September drawing on the left page, a May drawing on the right, the bear resting on the spine of the book. Caption: "The bear journal, opened at both ends of the year."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Pull out the bear journals from the whole year. Let each child reread theirs with you. Read aloud the first entry and the most recent one.
- Host a "bear reunion" with last year's class if possible. Children love seeing their bears with the bigger kids' bears.
- Make a class book of "Things Our Bears Learned This Year." Dictate.
- Invite families to a bear open house. Let the children give their families a tour.
- Return to the Welcome, Teacher scene with the children. Read them the first line of this guide. Ask, "Do you remember the first day?"

FROM A CLASSROOM

At the May open house, Nia's father stood in the doorway of the classroom and looked at the bear wall. He hadn't been to many school events this year. Nia pulled him by the hand to her September photo. "That was me," she said. He bent down to look. They stood there for a long time. He didn't say anything. Nia held her bear against her chest and leaned against her father's leg.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

When you look back at your year with this specific group of children, what has surprised you? What are you proud of? What do you want to remember?



June: A Good Goodbye

How we end things teaches children how to hold things they love. This is one of the most emotionally important themes of the year. Many teachers want to rush through endings or make them small. Resist. The goodbye is the curriculum.

The goodbye teaches children that painful things can be survived, that endings don't erase what came before, and that loss is a form of love. How you do goodbye becomes part of how these children do goodbye for the rest of their lives. Do it well.

[A folded letter tied with ribbon, resting on a bear's paw — the bear's goodbye letter to a child, waiting on the last day. Caption: "A letter from the bear, written in June."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Start the goodbye two to three weeks early. Don't wait for the last day.
- Decide whether bears go home or stay at school. If they stay, have a clear ritual for saying goodbye to them.
- Write each child a letter from their bear. Simple. Specific. "You taught me how to be brave. You held me when I was scared. I will miss you."
- Host a "bear graduation" on the last day. Slow. Ritualized. Not busy.
- Let yourself grieve. Tell the children you'll miss them. That is the lesson.

FROM A CLASSROOM

On the last day, Ms. Rosa read each child the letter she'd written from their bear. When she got to Eli's, she read it slowly, then handed it to him. He held it for a long time. He didn't say anything. He just hugged his bear, and then he hugged Ms. Rosa, and then he went to find his mom in the hallway.

FOR YOUR REFLECTION GROUP

What do you need in order to grieve this year's children well? Who can hold that grief with you? What is the smallest, most specific ritual you want to do at the end?



Four Anytime Themes

These themes don't have months. They emerge when children need them. A child gets sick, and suddenly everyone needs bears at the hospital. A family configuration comes up in conversation, and suddenly families become central. Use these themes when the moment calls for them, or weave them through the year.

Hurting & Healing: Bears Get Boo-Boos Too

Bodies matter. Scrapes, bumps, illness, hospitals — all of these activate fear in children. Bears can help children approach their own physical experiences with less terror and more story.

This theme becomes urgent whenever a child in your room is sick, injured, or going through a medical procedure.

[The bear hospital in the dramatic play area — bear on a small cot, band-aids on its paw, toy stethoscope draped across its chest. A child's hand gently smoothing its fur. Caption: "The bear hospital, Tuesday after the ambulance."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Keep a small bear first-aid kit (band-aids, a toy stethoscope, a cloth sling) in the dramatic play area.
- "Your bear has a hurt. What would help your bear feel better?" Let children doctor their bears.
- Read books about bodies and doctors. Let bears come to the doctor with the children.

- When a child is going to the doctor or hospital, send a bear with them if possible, and a letter: "Our bear is going with you."
- After illness or injury, welcome the bear back. "Your bear has been through a lot. We're glad you're both back."

FROM A CLASSROOM

When Tomas came back from the hospital after his asthma attack, his teacher had set up a bear hospital in the dramatic play area. Tomas went straight to it. He put his bear on the small cot. He used the toy stethoscope to listen to the bear's chest. He whispered something into the bear's ear. He stayed there for forty-five minutes. When another child tried to join, Tomas said, "Not yet." He went back to the bear and started again.



Teddy Bear Families (of All Kinds)

Every configuration of family is honored. Grandparents raising children, single parents, two moms, two dads, foster families, adoptive families, children raising siblings, blended families, extended families, chosen families. All of it.

This theme is urgent whenever family configuration comes up in class — and it will — and urgent for any child whose family doesn't look like the families in most children's books.

[A child-drawn bear family on construction paper — three mom-sized shapes, a grandma shape, a baby bear — taped next to a bear on the family wall. Caption: "This is my bear's family."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Read *All Families Are Special*, *Families Are Different*, *Two Homes*, and books that reflect the actual families in your room.
- "Who is in your bear's family?" Draw them. Dictate their names.
- Build bear houses that reflect the real housing situations in your class — apartments, trailers, houses, grandparent homes, two homes.
- Invite families to send a family photo for the bear's home.
- Never correct a child who describes a family configuration that differs from what you expected. "My bear has two mommies and a nana." The right response is, "Tell me about them."

FROM A CLASSROOM

Ezra lived with his mom and his grandmother. He had never met his father. When the class made bear families one morning, Ezra drew a mom, a grandmother, and a bear. His teacher, Ms. Tali, sat down beside him. "Tell me about your bear's family," she said. Ezra didn't look up from his drawing. "His mom. His grandma. Him." He kept coloring. After a minute he added, quietly, "Same as mine."



Friends & Bear Friends

Friendship is where so much of childhood happens. It's also where so much can go wrong. Bears help children explore friendship — what it is, what it means, what it feels like — and practice the small repairs that friendships require.

This theme is always relevant. Young children are constantly making and unmaking friendships. Bears offer a rehearsal space.

[Two bears sitting side by side at a small table, a shared plate of pretend snack between them. Two small hands adjusting their paws. Caption: "Bears working it out."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Pair bears up for the day. "Today your bear has a bear friend. Who is your bear's friend?"
- Read *Bear's New Friend* and *My Friend Bear*.
- When children are in conflict, let the bears mediate. "Our bears are trying to figure this out. What are they saying?"
- Celebrate repair, not just kindness. "Your bear said sorry to its friend. That's brave."
- Post Vivian Paley's rule where the children can see it: You can't say you can't play.

FROM A CLASSROOM

Maya and Ruth had been best friends in September. By January, something had shifted, and they couldn't seem to play together without fighting. Their teacher, Ms. Joelle, had the two of them sit with their bears at a small table one afternoon. "Let your bears work it out," she said. The two bears talked for a long time. (The children talked for a long time.) When Ms. Joelle came back to check, the bears were sitting next to each other and Maya was building a small block tower for both of them. The argument hadn't gotten resolved exactly. But the bears had given the girls a way to sit at the same table again.



Coming Back: Bears Welcome You Home

Reunion after absences is its own theme. A child comes back after being sick, after a break, after a move, after a crisis. The bear is waiting.

Post-Helene, this theme became central. Many of our children had been displaced. Coming back was a ritual that had to be named, every time, for the child to feel held.

[A bear waiting at a child's empty cubby — spot untouched, a folded paper note leaned against its chest. Caption: "She waited for me."]

TRY THIS WEEK

- Keep each child's bear in the same spot on their cubby or shelf. When they come back, the bear is exactly where they left it.
- Greet the bear before you greet the child. "Your bear has been waiting for you."
- For longer absences, let the bear "write" a short note the child comes back to: "I missed you. I kept your spot."
- Announce the return to the class. "Mateo is back. Mateo's bear is very happy."
- Protect the first five minutes after a long absence for quiet reunion. Not assessment. Not catch-up. Just welcome.

FROM A CLASSROOM

Kiara had been out for three weeks after her family lost their house in the flood. On the day she came back, her teacher had placed her bear at her cubby with a small paper heart taped to its paw. Kiara stood in the doorway for a long moment before she went to her cubby. She picked up the bear. She read the heart. Her mother, watching from the hallway, put her hand over her mouth. Kiara came into the room holding the bear close. She didn't say anything. She walked over to the rug and sat down where she always used to sit.



Bears at Every Age

The function of the bear stays the same across the early years. The form changes. A toddler and a kindergartener are doing the same developmental work — using the bear as a safe distance for what's too big to hold alone — but what it looks like is very different.

Age	What you may notice	What the bear is doing	What to invite
18–24 months	Carries bear constantly. Holds it at transitions, naps, meals. Cannot tolerate bear being out of sight.	The bear is the mother, symbolically. It holds attachment across distance.	Let the bear travel with the child. Keep it near at all transitions. Don't separate the child from the bear for any reason.
2–3 years	Begins to name the bear. Brief conversations with it. May hit or bite the bear when angry, hug it when sad.	The bear is the child's first object of emotional practice. Feelings can be rehearsed on the bear.	Mirror the feeling the child shows to the bear. Accept all feelings toward the bear without alarm.
3–4 years	Bears have names, friends, families, stories. Children act out scenarios. Bears go to the doctor, to school, on trips.	The bear is a character in the child's developing inner life. Stories are where meaning is built.	Become a co-narrator. "And then what happened?" Offer wondering rather than explaining. Let the stories get dark; that's often the point.
4–5 years	Bears have elaborate worlds and histories. Children may write or dictate stories about them. Bears may "speak" for the child about hard subjects.	The bear is a sophisticated symbol. It can hold nuance — a bear can be sad and brave at the same time.	Dictation, journals, class books. Let children speak through the bear when they can't speak as themselves. Read those words back.
5–6 years	Bears become more private. Children may no longer carry them openly but reach for them at bedtime, during illness, in crisis.	The bear is an internalized companion. The bear now lives inside the child as well as outside.	Respect the privacy. Don't force the bear into every moment. Keep the bear available, visible, and undisturbed.

Bears in Different Nervous Systems

Not all children engage with sensory input in the same way. Some seek more input. Some need less. Some watch before engaging. Bears work differently for each, and understanding this helps you honor how each child's nervous system works.

This isn't an accommodation chapter. It's a lens. Neurodiversity-affirming practice isn't what you do for some children; it's what you do for every child, because every child's nervous system is different from every other child's.

Three Sensory Styles

Style	What you may see	How bears help
Seekers	Wiggle constantly. Seek crashing, squeezing, spinning. Hold bears tight, squeeze them hard, bury their face in fur.	Bears are a safe target for big sensory input. Let children squeeze, stack, wrestle, burrow. Offer heavy bears or bears wrapped in weighted blankets.
Avoiders	Pull back from loud, bright, crowded, messy. May be overwhelmed by too many choices or too many textures.	Bears can be a retreat from a too-busy room. Choose a smooth-fabric bear. Keep the bear's home small and quiet.
Observers	Watch before engaging. Need more time to warm up to new people, materials, and routines. Quieter in groups.	The bear gives an observer something to hold while they watch. They can engage through the bear before they engage directly.

Proprioceptive Input: Bears as Partners

Proprioceptive input is the deep pressure that helps a nervous system calm and organize. Many children seek it without knowing they need it. Bears can help.

A weighted bear, a firmly-squeezed bear, a bear held tight against the chest or stomach — all give a child the steady, deep pressure their body is asking for. For children who are dysregulated, a bear hug can do more than a conversation. Teach children: "When your body feels buzzy, your bear can help. Hold your bear right here, against your heart, and breathe."

BEARS AND AUTISTIC CHILDREN

Many autistic children will form an unusually deep, sustained relationship with their bear — naming it, dressing it, talking to it, returning to it across the day with a consistency that other children may not match. This isn't a deficit, and the relationship isn't a substitute for human connection — it is connection, rendered in a form that may be safer for that child to begin with. Honor it.

Some autistic children will find specific sensory features of the bear (the eyes, the seams, certain textures) genuinely irritating; offer choice in which bear they get, and never insist. As always, talk with your team about any child whose sensory or relational needs are complex — but begin from the assumption that the bear is a friend, not a therapy.

Bears & Literacy

Play and literacy aren't in competition. Play is how children learn that language carries meaning. Bears create a context where children want to read, write, and tell stories.

Vivian Paley, whose work on storytelling in classrooms is one of the most important foundations of early literacy, reminds us that the stories children tell each other are the stories they can later read. The bear gives children a character to tell stories about — a character they already love.

"Being told you can't play is a serious matter. It hurts more than anything else that happens in school."

— Vivian Paley

[An open bear journal: child's drawing on the left page, teacher's dictation in neat printing on the right — "My bear went to the hospital and the doctor said he is going to be okay." The bear sits on the corner of the page. Caption: "The child's words, written down exactly as spoken."]

Bear Journals: From Oral to Written

A bear journal is a child's story about their bear. It might be a picture. It might be a sentence. It might be a paragraph. It might be dictation. All of it counts.

For Pre-Writers

Children draw or paint their bears. You sit beside them and ask: "Tell me about your bear." You write down their words, exactly as spoken. You read them back. The child watches their words appear on paper.

This is dictation, and it's the bridge between oral and written language. A child says: "My bear went to the hospital and the doctor said he is going to be okay." You write it down. You read it back. Two things happen at once: the child discovers that print carries meaning, and the child discovers that their story matters enough to be written down.

Dictation is underused in most classrooms because it looks slow. It isn't slow. It's the fastest way for a pre-writer to understand what writing is for. One five-minute dictation session, done well, teaches more about the relationship between speech and print than an hour of worksheet letter practice. Do it often.

For Emergent Writers

Children write letters, words, approximations. You don't correct. You celebrate. "You wrote a story about your bear!" Invented spelling isn't a problem. Invented spelling is thinking.

For More Accomplished Writers

Children write longer stories, narratives, reflections. "My bear learned that it's okay to be scared." "My bear's favorite thing is when we sit together at quiet time." These journals become keepsakes. Parents cry over them in June.

Class Books

Class books are a communal version of bear journals. Every child contributes a page. The class reads them at morning meeting. Over the course of a year, you'll make six or eight or ten of these. They live on a low shelf where children can pull them out on their own, and they do. Children will sit at the book area and read class books together the way adults reread family photo albums.

Themes that work well: All Our Bears Together (September). My Bear's Feelings (December). When My Bear Was Brave (February). Our Teddy Bear Town (April). Goodbye, Dear Bear (June).

Connective Read-Alouds

Read books that connect to bear themes. Before, during, and after the read-aloud, weave in bear connections. The bear is the child's co-listener; the child's feelings about the book can live in the bear.

- Reading The Goodbye Book: "This book is about saying goodbye. Does your bear ever feel this way?"
- Reading The Rabbit Listened: "Who does your bear want to sit next to when your bear is sad?"
- Reading Corduroy: "Has your bear ever felt lost? Has your bear ever been found?"

See Appendix D for a full thematic list.

PART SIX

Your Toolkit

Print, photocopy, tape to your wall

[A flat-lay of the toolkit in use: a laminated Me Check card, a Daily Bear Note on a sticky, the open Reflective Language Bank taped inside a classroom door. Marker caps, a coffee cup edge, a child's crayon drawing tucked beneath. Caption: "The toolkit, in real classroom weather."]

Quick Reference

The four sentences you may need in the middle of a hard moment. Photocopy this page. Post it on the inside of your classroom door, in your planning binder, on the back of your sign-in clipboard.

IN THE MIDDLE OF A HARD MOMENT

1. Notice. Before I say anything, what am I seeing? (The child's body. The bear's position. What just happened in the room.)
2. Invite the feeling, contain the behavior. "Your bear seems really angry. I won't let your bear hurt the other bears."
3. Stay close, stay quiet. My presence is the intervention. I don't have to fix this.
4. Me Check. Am I in my adult self right now, or is my Little Self in the room? If my Little Self is in the room, three slow breaths before I speak again.

Tool 1: Daily Bear Note

At the end of each day, three lines. Takes 30 seconds. Sticky note, phone, back of an envelope. The third line is what makes the practice generative over time.

[A sticky note on a planner page with three short lines written in pen — name, body-word, question. A travel mug in the corner. Caption: "Three lines. Thirty seconds."]

DAILY BEAR NOTE

Today I noticed: [child's name] [what you saw]

What I felt in my body: [one word or short phrase]

A question I'm sitting with: [optional]

Over a year, this becomes about 180 sentences. Keep them. At the end of the year, read them in order. That collection is the most honest data anyone will ever generate about your teaching. It will show you, more clearly than any observation or rubric, who you are when you're paying attention.

Tool 2: Weekly Reflection Group — Simple Agenda

Thirty to forty-five minutes. No preparation needed. One facilitator, who is the keeper of the frame, not the keeper of the answers.

- Settling (3 minutes). One minute of silence. Then a Me Check round: each person names, in one phrase, how their body is right now.
- Sharing (15–20 minutes). Each teacher brings one bear moment from the week and one question. Others listen. No advice yet.
- Wondering (10–15 minutes). The group picks one moment to wonder about together. Use the phrase "I wonder if...". The teacher who shared doesn't have to answer.
- Closing (3 minutes). Each person names one thing they want to try, notice, or ask about in the week ahead.

What the facilitator protects: confidentiality, the no-advice frame during Sharing, and the teacher's right to say "I don't know" out loud.

Tool 3: Five Self-Check Domains

Use at the start, middle, and end of the year. Not a grade — a mirror. Sit with each question for a minute before answering. Use the same journal across the three times you do it, so you can see your own thinking change.

Identity & Belonging

Whose identity is most visible in our room? Whose is least visible? What would I need to change about our materials, our books, or our routines for that to be different?

Emotional Range

Which feelings feel easiest to welcome here? Which ones make me want to redirect? What does that pattern tell me about myself?

Curiosity & Voice

Where in our day are children most curious? Where do they go quiet? What might be getting in the way?

Relationship & Repair

Which child do I feel most connected to right now? Which child do I feel furthest from? What would it take to close that distance by an inch?

Felt Safety

When was the last time a child showed me, with their body, that they felt safe here? When was the last time a child showed me they didn't?

Tool 4: Reflective Language Bank

The strongest page in your toolkit. When words feel hard, these phrases are here. Tape it to the wall.

When a child is sad, scared, or carrying something big

- "Your bear looks like it needs some comfort right now. Would you like to hold it in the cozy corner?"
- "I can see your bear is having a hard day. I'm right here."
- "Your bear looks worried. I wonder what it needs to feel safe."
- "Sometimes after scary things happen, bears need extra holding. Your bear is lucky to have you."

When a child throws or mistreats their bear

- "Ouch! Poor bear! It looks like it's too hard to hold your bear right now. How about bear stays with me until you feel ready."
- "Your bear is safe. You are safe. When you're ready, I'll give bear back to you."

Never take bears away as punishment. Hold the bear for the child. The bear waits.

When a child won't touch their bear

- "Your bear is right here whenever you're ready. No rush."
- "Some bears take a while to warm up. Your bear can watch from over here."
- "I'll keep your bear safe until you want it back."

When play reflects something hard

- "Your bear is building something really strong. I wonder what it's keeping safe in there."
- "Your bear has been to the doctor a lot today. It sounds like your bear knows a lot about that."
- "Your bear's house got knocked down and you're building it again. That's what people do after hard things — they rebuild."

When you want to invite deeper play

- "I notice your bear is building something. Tell me about it — when you're ready."
- "Your bear seems like it has a story to tell. I'd love to hear it if your bear wants to share."
- "I wonder what your bear is thinking."

At transitions

- "Time to put your bear in its safe place. Your bear will be right here when you come back."
- "Bear will wait for us. Let's go."

At end of day

- "Your bear had a good day with you. Tell your bear one thing you liked about today."
- "Bear will be right here tomorrow. I'll see you then."

The words don't have to be perfect. They have to be warm, genuine, and about the bear.

Tool 5: The Me Check Card

A wallet-sized version of the two questions. Print this. Cut it out. Put it in your pocket, your lanyard, or the inside cover of your plan book. Ten seconds. Every time.

[The Me Check Card, cut out and laminated, tucked into the clear pocket of a lanyard. Caption: "Ten seconds. Every time."]

ME CHECK • CUT OUT • CARRY WITH YOU

Before I walk in — before I greet — before I speak:

1. How am I right now, in my body?
2. Can I be present for a child who needs me?

If no, three slow breaths. Or a minute in the hallway. Or a sentence to a co-teacher. It's allowed.

— *How you are is how they will be.*

Tool 6: When to Bring It to Supervision

You don't have to know what to do alone. Bring something to supervision if...

- A child's play is repetitive, driven, or compulsive — the same scene, same script, no resolution — for more than two weeks.
- A child's affect during bear play is consistently flat, numb, or disconnected.
- A child suddenly stops engaging with their bear after a period of strong connection.
- A child's bear play involves themes you find yourself unable to watch without distress.
- A child's behavior outside bear play has changed — more aggressive, more withdrawn, more clingy — and the change has lasted more than a few days.

- A child has disclosed something — directly or through the bear — that you're required to report, or that you aren't sure whether you're required to report.
- A family member has said something to you that has stayed in your body and you don't know why.
- Any moment where your own body told you something was wrong, even if you can't name what.

Bringing something to supervision isn't a failure and isn't a diagnosis. It's an act of care — for the child, for yourself, and for the practice.

CLOSING

An Invitation

*[The last light of a classroom afternoon: chairs stacked, lights dim, one bear sitting upright on a low shelf. The door slightly open.
Caption: "End of a good day."]*

This guide isn't a script. It isn't a program. It isn't one more thing on your plate.

It's an invitation to notice.

To notice the child who holds their bear a little tighter on Mondays. The child who gives their bear a different name every week. The child who builds a home for their bear and then knocks it down and builds it again. The child whose bear sits quietly on the shelf and waits.

The bears won't fix anything. They won't solve behavior problems or close achievement gaps or make your classroom look like a Pinterest board. What they will do, if you let them, is create a space where a child can be seen, and heard, and accompanied by someone steady.

That someone is you.

Every time a child feels seen through the safe distance of a teddy bear, something shifts. They learn that their feelings matter. That their story has a place. That there are adults who will stay.

"The bear isn't the strategy. The relationship is. The bear just makes it safe enough to begin."

Thank you for doing this work. It matters more than you know.



Gabriel Guyton and Skylar Belt

ConnectEd Circles LLC

Grounded in the Emotionally Responsive Practice of Bank Street College of Education, founded by Lesley Koplou.

Appendices

Appendix A: A Map of This Guide

This guide is organized in three layers:

- What You Need to Know (Parts One through Five): the ideas, research, and stories that ground this practice.
- What You Can Try (throughout, in teal boxes): concrete, practical things you can do this week.
- What You Can Bring to Your Group (purple boxes): reflection questions for the Weekly Reflection Group or coaching conversations.

The boxes and colors serve different purposes:

- Teal boxes: specific try-this suggestions for this week.
- Cream boxes: stories from actual classrooms (composites, drawn from our network).
- Purple boxes: reflection group prompts.
- Peach boxes: what to watch for; what these moments might mean.
- Sage green boxes: notes on neurodiversity and sensory variation.
- Warm cream warning boxes: the few short pages we hope you'll come back to often.

A note on the stories. The classroom stories in this guide are composites — drawn from our own teaching, from the teachers in our network, from families we've worked with. Names, details, and situations have been changed or combined. The feelings in them are real. They're offered in the tradition of Amy Laura Dombro's storytelling work with early childhood teachers, where a good story is often truer than any single fact.

Appendix B: Dear Families / Queridas Familias

English

Dear Families,

This year, each child in our classroom will have their own stuffed teddy bear. The bears will stay at school — they're part of our classroom community, not toys to take home.

The bears aren't behavior management tools. They will never be used as punishment or taken away. Instead, the bears are companions for feelings. When a child is sad, scared, happy, or excited, their bear is there. The bears help children express feelings they don't yet have words for.

Each child will choose and name their bear early in the year. Over time, children will personalize them, build homes for them, tell them stories, and hold them during hard moments. You may notice your child talking about their bear at home, or asking questions about it. This is exactly what we hope for.

We invite you into this practice. If you have questions about how bears are used in our classroom, or if you'd like to understand this approach better, we welcome your questions. Our goal is simple: to create a classroom where every child feels seen and held, both by the adult teachers and by the small soft companion on their lap.

With warmth,

[Teacher name and classroom]

Español

Queridas Familias,

Este año, cada niño en nuestro salón de clases tendrá su propio oso de peluche. Los osos se quedarán en la escuela — son parte de nuestra comunidad del salón, no juguetes para llevar a casa.

Los osos no son herramientas de manejo del comportamiento. Nunca se usarán como castigo ni se quitarán. En su lugar, los osos son compañeros para los sentimientos. Cuando un niño está triste, asustado, feliz o emocionado, su oso está allí. Los osos ayudan a los niños a expresar sentimientos para los que aún no tienen palabras.

Cada niño elegirá y nombrará su oso a principios de año. Con el tiempo, los niños los personalizarán, construirán casas para ellos, les contarán historias y los abrazarán durante momentos difíciles. Es posible que note que su hijo habla sobre su oso en casa o hace preguntas al respecto. Esto es exactamente lo que esperamos.

Los invitamos a participar en esta práctica. Si tiene preguntas sobre cómo se usan los osos en nuestro salón, o si desea comprender mejor este enfoque, agradeceremos sus preguntas. Nuestro objetivo es simple: crear un salón donde cada niño se sienta visto y sostenido, tanto por los maestros adultos como por el pequeño compañero suave en su regazo.

Con cariño,

[Nombre del maestro y salón de clases]

Note on translation: We translated into Spanish first because of our region's primary second language. If your program serves families who read Vietnamese, Mandarin, Arabic, Russian, Ukrainian, Karen, Burmese, Pashto, Haitian Creole, or any other language not represented here, please send us a translation we can add to the Hub for the next program that needs it.

Appendix C: ITERS/ECERS Crosswalk

This crosswalk helps directors, licensors, and quality reviewers see how the bear practice supports existing environmental rating scales. It isn't a compliance document; it's a translation.

ITERS-3 / ECERS-3 Indicator	Where this practice supports it
Space and Furnishings — Room arrangement for play	The bear home, cozy corner, and dramatic play accommodations (Part Two). Bears at child-height, visible from the door.
Personal Care Routines — Greeting and departure	Bear-mediated arrival and transitions; the bear holds the middle (Part Two, Daily Rhythms). Coming Back anytime theme (Part Five).
Language and Literacy — Helping children use language	Bear journals, dictation, class books, connective read-alouds (Part Five). Reflective Language Bank (Tool 4).
Language and Literacy — Using books	Connective Read-Alouds by theme (Appendix D). Class book practice (Part Five).
Learning Activities — Dramatic play	Teddy Bear Town (April theme), bear homes, bear families, bear hospital (Part Five).
Learning Activities — Art, Music, Nature	Bear songs (Appendix E). Bear drawings and paintings as dictation prompts (Part Five).
Interaction — Individualized teaching	Notice · Join · Make Meaning posture (Parts One and Three). Five Self-Check Domains (Tool 3).
Interaction — Staff-child interactions	Mirror, Don't Fix; Inviting and Containing; Me Check (Parts One, Three, Four).
Interaction — Peer interactions	Friends & Bear Friends (Part Five). Paley's "you can't say you can't play" (literacy section).
Program Structure — Free play	Guided play with bears (Parts One and Two).
Parents and Staff — Provisions for parents	Dear Families letter, family partnerships chapter, open house practice (Part Four, Appendix B).
Parents and Staff — Supervision and evaluation	Reflection group, Self-Check, For Facilitators (Parts Four and Six, Appendix G).

Appendix D: Connective Read-Alouds by Theme

These books are selected for their emotional honesty. Let children hold their bears while you read. The bear becomes a co-listener, making the story feel safer.

Welcoming & Identity

For September and October; also for any moment when a new child or family enters the class.

- I Will Keep You Safe and Sound (Houran)
- Corduroy (Freeman)
- The Day You Begin (Woodson)
- Alma and How She Got Her Name (Martinez-Neal)
- Eyes That Kiss in the Corners (Ho)
- The Colors of Us (Katz)

Feelings

For December and any moment when a child is working on a big feeling.

- How Big Are Your Worries Little Bear (Sanders)
- The Rabbit Listened (Doerrfeld)
- Grumpy Monkey (Lang)
- Bear Feels Scared (Wilson)
- I'm Happy-Sad Today (Britain)
- The Feelings Book (Parr)
- Go Away Big Green Monster (Emberley)

Separation & Reunion

For November, the days around any break, and for children who are struggling with drop-off.

- The Kissing Hand (Penn)
- Owl Babies (Waddell)
- Llama Llama Misses Mama (Dewdney)
- The Invisible String (Karst)
- Bye-Bye Time (Verdick)

Families

For the Teddy Bear Families anytime theme, and whenever a family configuration comes up in class.

- All Families Are Special (Simon)
- Families (Rottner)
- Families Are Different (Pellegrini)
- Two Homes (Masurel)
- A Family is a Family is a Family (O'Leary)

Loss & Change

For January, and for any time a child or family has experienced a loss.

- The Memory Box (Rowland)
- Ida Always (Levis)
- Badger's Parting Gifts (Varley)
- When Dinosaurs Die (Brown)
- Leo the Late Bloomer (Kraus)

Friendship & Community

For April's Teddy Bear Town and the Friends & Bear Friends anytime theme.

- Bear's New Friend (Wilson)
- My Friend Bear (Alborough)
- Last Stop on Market Street (de la Peña)
- Thank You Omu (Mora)

Bears & Comfort

For rest time, hard moments, and endings.

- Where's My Teddy (Alborough)
- Kiss Good Night (Hest)
- Good Night Baby Bear (Asch)
- Ira Sleeps Over (Waber)
- Old Bear (Henkes)
- Teddy Bear Tears (Aylesworth)

Appendix E: Bear Songs Collection

These songs are organized by what they do for children's bodies. Calming songs slow things down; use at settling, rest, and transitions. Organizing songs help children find a steady rhythm;

use during routines and body-awareness play. Alerting songs bring energy up; use with care for already-dysregulated groups.

Calming Songs

Use at drop-off, rest time, after hard moments, and during transitions that need softening. Sung slowly, with a hand on the heart or on the bear's back.

- "Hello, Teddy Bear"
- "You Are a Part of Me"
- "Teddy Bear Turn Around" (slow)
- "Bear Is Here"
- "Rock-a-Bye Bear"

Organizing Songs

Use during morning meeting, clean-up, and body-awareness play. These songs give children a steady beat that their bodies can find.

- "Going on a Bear Hunt"
- "Bear's Body Song"
- "This Is the Way We Take Care of Bear"
- "Bear's Heart Beats Slow, Bear's Heart Beats Fast"

Alerting Songs

Use with care. Alerting songs bring the group up — use them to wake a sleepy group or celebrate a moment, not to escalate an already-buzzy room.

- "Teddy Bear Turn Around" (fast)
- "Bears in the Bed"
- "Shake Your Bear"

Appendix F: When a Child Speaks of Loss

Children sometimes bring grief into the classroom — a pet, a grandparent, a friend who moved, a home that's no longer home. These moments come through the bear, and they come quickly. This table gives you language that welcomes the feeling without making promises you can't keep. Read it before you need it.

"We invite the feeling. We contain the behavior."

— Lesley Koplow

What the child says	What the child may be doing	A response that welcomes, not fixes
"My bear's grandma died."	Borrowing the bear to approach their own loss at a safe distance.	"That is a hard thing for your bear. Do you want to tell me about her?"
"Is my grandma in heaven?"	Asking a real question about meaning and permanence.	"Different families believe different things. What does your family say?"
"Can you tell my bear it's going to be okay?"	Asking for comfort without wanting a guarantee.	Take the bear's paw. "It's going to be okay. And it's also okay to miss her."
"My bear doesn't want to talk about it."	Needing to not talk about it, using the bear as cover.	"That's okay. Your bear doesn't have to. I'll just sit here."
(Child is silent, bear pressed tight to chest.)	Holding a feeling too big for words.	Sit nearby. Hand near, not on. "I'm right here." That's enough.
"My bear wishes he could see her again."	Naming longing. Don't redirect.	"Yes. Wishing is part of missing someone."
"What happens when bears die?"	Asking the real question under the question.	"What are you wondering about?" Let the child lead.

What to avoid: "She's in a better place." "At least you had her for so long." "Be brave." "Don't cry." "You'll feel better soon." These phrases are well-meant and they close the conversation. Welcome the feeling. Contain the behavior. Let the child know, with your body, that their grief fits in this room.

Appendix G: For Facilitators, Coaches & Supervisors

If you're reading this and you're the person who works with teachers — coaching them, supervising them, facilitating their groups — this appendix is for you. Your practice mirrors what we've asked teachers to do with children. It should. The method runs all the way through.

The Thesis: Parallel Process

Your first job is to be a mirror for the teacher, the same way she's being a mirror for the child. The bear helps children feel safe enough to speak their truth. Your job is to do that for teachers.

When a teacher brings you a hard bear moment, the temptation is to reassure, to solve, to suggest. Resist. The teacher doesn't need you to tell her it's fine. She needs you to be with her the way she's trying to be with the child. Notice the feeling under the telling. Wonder aloud about what the moment might mean. Leave silence. Silence is where the teacher finds her own next step.

The Notice · Join · Make Meaning posture works at every level of the system. With children. With teachers. With colleagues. With yourself.

Your Practice

- Hold the frame. You aren't the curriculum. You're the conditions under which the curriculum can happen. Protect the reflection group's time. Protect its confidentiality. Protect the teachers' right to be imperfect out loud.
- Mirror first. When a teacher brings you a story, resist the urge to solve. Reflect what you heard. Name the feeling under the telling. Wonder aloud about what the moment might hold.
- Tend your own Little Self. You were once a child in someone's classroom too. A teacher's hard story will activate you. Notice when it does. Bring that to your own supervision before you bring it to hers.
- Hold the non-negotiables without apology. The Things We Never Do With Bears in Part Two aren't style preferences. If you see them slipping, name it — kindly and clearly. That's care.
- Make space for repair. Teachers will snap at children. You'll snap at teachers. Model what repair looks like. "I wasn't listening well yesterday. I want to come back to what you said." Teachers learn repair from you the way children learn it from them.

Running a Reflection Group: Notes for the Facilitator

The agenda is in Tool 2 (Part Six). The structure is simple. The skill is in what you don't do.

- Don't rush the silence. The first minute of silence at the start is the work, not the warm-up. Some teachers will fidget. Let them.
- Don't let advice creep in during Sharing. "Have you tried —?" derails the work. Catch it gently. "Let's hold the question for now and come back to it in Wondering."
- Don't take the bait when a teacher tells a story that begs you to solve it. The hardest discipline is to ask one more wondering question instead of offering one piece of advice.
- Don't break confidentiality, ever. If a teacher's story raises a safety concern about a child, address it privately and through the appropriate channels — never in the room.
- Don't interpret. "It sounds like you're really worried about this child" is a mirror. "Sounds like you're also worried about your own daughter" is interpretation. Stay on the surface the teacher offered you.

When You're the Coach Doing Walkthroughs

- Walk slowly. Notice the bear shelf, the cozy corner, the family wall. Ask yourself: what would a child see when they walked in?

- Look for the floor of the practice (the Things We Never Do list) before you look for the ceiling. If a teacher is doing the floor consistently, the rest will come.
- Bring one observation to your debrief, not a list. The teacher can take in one new thing per conversation. Anything more is for you, not for her.
- Ask a wondering question before you offer a suggestion. "I noticed Marisa stayed in the cozy corner for a long time on Tuesday. What were you thinking about during that?" Then listen.

Appendix H: For the Director

If you're the program director, executive director, or principal who bought this guide for your staff: thank you. Here's what we want you to know before you hand it out.

"Every child who winds up doing well has had at least one stable and committed relationship with a supportive adult."

— Jack Shonkoff, Center on the Developing Child

The teachers in your program are often that adult. Your job is to make it possible for them to stay that adult — under time pressure, under parent complaints, under the thousand small erosions of the school year. Everything below is in service of that.

This is a year-long practice, not a workshop.

A single training day will not produce the results this guide describes. Plan for monthly or biweekly reflection groups for at least one school year. The teachers who use this well will be the ones who have time and structure to talk together about what they're seeing.

Your job is to protect the conditions, not to monitor the practice.

Teachers won't be vulnerable enough for this work to land if they're also being evaluated on it. Keep the reflection groups confidential. Keep the bear journals private. If you want to assess the program, use the Self-Check, the Environment Walkthrough, and (with permission) a Fidelity Checklist — not the teachers' own reflective writing.

Your own posture sets the ceiling.

Teachers can't hold children with more emotional steadiness than the leadership above them models. If you want emotionally responsive classrooms, lead an emotionally responsive program. Take the Me Check yourself before staff meetings. Welcome teachers' hard feelings the way you want them to welcome children's. The parallel process runs all the way up.

Budget for the floor.

Bears, replacement bears, washing supplies, and one paid hour of reflection per teacher per week. That's the floor. Anything less is asking teachers to do this work without scaffolding. They will, because they're teachers — but it'll cost them.

Talk with families about the program before it starts.

Use the Dear Families letter in Appendix B, translated into the languages your families read. Be ready for questions. Some families will love the practice immediately. Some will be confused. A few may worry that bears are unhygienic, babyish, or culturally unfamiliar. All of these are reasonable. Have answers ready, and listen more than you explain.

Decide in advance what this practice cannot do.

Reread "What This Practice Cannot Do" in Part One. Make sure your team knows what the bears are not. A bear program used as a stand-in for real mental health infrastructure will do harm.

Plan for hard stories.

Children will disclose things through the bear. Know your state's mandated reporting law before the bears arrive. Know the name and number of at least one child mental health consultant before you need one. Put this information in a visible place for every teacher.

Celebrate quiet wins.

Most of the change this practice produces won't show up on a rubric. It'll show up in a child's shoulders. In a drop-off that used to last fifteen minutes and now lasts two. In a family who came to the open house for the first time. Notice these. Name them. Tell your board about them. Protect the small things.

Thank you for taking this on. The teachers in your program are doing one of the most important jobs in our country. The bears are one small way of telling them, and the children in their care, that we know.

Appendix I: Bear Environment Walkthrough

Use this checklist to audit your bear setup. Do the walkthrough at the start of the year and again mid-year. The question isn't whether you can check every box; it's what you notice while you walk.

- Bears are visible from the door when a child enters the room.
- Bear homes are at child height (not on a high shelf or in a teacher cupboard).
- A cozy corner or designated soft space exists for bear comfort, and isn't used as a timeout.

- Materials for bear play are accessible (blocks, fabric, dolls, small dishes, a doctor kit, a toy phone).
- Bear books are shelved where children can reach them.
- A feelings chart or emotions visual is visible at child height.
- The dramatic play area accommodates bears (kitchen, hospital corner, bear families, etc.).
- A class book or documentation features bears and children's play.
- A predictable place exists for rest-time bears (cubbies, shelf, basket near cots).
- Family communication about bears is current and posted (in the families' languages).
- At least one bear-related photograph of each child is posted at child height.
- A rotation for washing bears is visible to the teacher.
- A backup bear is available for a child who arrives mid-year or whose bear is lost.

Appendix J: Selected References

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